

Session 14: The Tree of Knowing Good and Bad

Key Takeaways

- The knowledge of good and bad is not an immoral thing that God wants to keep from humans. When the phrase is used elsewhere in the Bible, it indicates moral maturity.
- This tree doesn't represent knowledge; it represents the choice to trust God or not. Will humans let God be their source of wisdom and knowledge, or will they reach out and take what seems good in their own eyes?
- The two trees in the garden are an archetype of the test all humans will eventually face.

The Tree of Knowing Good and Bad

The trees are introduced in [Genesis 2:9](#) and appear again in [Genesis 2:16-17](#).

"[The tree of life] represents life that is beyond the original life that God breathed into human. The first human by nature is susceptible to death ... Nevertheless, continued eating from the tree could renew life and prevent death. Apart from disobedience to God's command, mortals had access to this tree ... The tree of life allows humanity to transcend its mortality, the state in which it was created on the sixth day, so it can move to a higher dimension ... to eternal life and immortality. As one partakes of this ... fruit by faith, one participates in this eternal life. This highest potency of life was available in the garden and becomes once again available to us as we reenter the temple-garden through the second Adam ... and look forward to the resurrection of our bodies."

Waltke, Bruce and Chales Yu (2007). [An Old Testament Theology: An Exegetical, Canonical, and Thematic Approach](#). Zondervan.

This Edenic state is fragile and conditional upon trusting and living by God's command. In Genesis 1, God alone is the provider and knower of what is good and not good. That is, he has the wisdom to know what is necessary for humanity to fulfill their role as God's partners in the "gardenizing" all of creation. This dignified role for the humans, however, comes with a great responsibility and choice. Will they learn wisdom from God, or will they take it for themselves?

In the "good" garden, there are trees loaded with fruit for eating and cultivating, and in the center of the garden (from which flows the river) is the tree of life. It's an image of God's ultimate gift to creation—the opportunity to share in and receive God's own goodness and life into oneself.

But ongoing access to the tree of life is conditional upon not taking from the tree of knowing *toṽ* and *ra*. The meaning of this phrase is important for the logic of the narrative, so we must take a deep dive into the meaning of these key words.

Good (Heb. *Tov*) and Bad/Evil (Heb. *Ra*)

Let's look at the words *tov* and *ra* in the Hebrew Bible to develop a portrait for our definition of these terms.

Good/Bad in Condition or Quality

Jeremiah 24:1-2 NIV*

... the LORD showed me two baskets of figs placed in front of the temple of the LORD. 2 One basket had very **tov** figs, like those that ripen early; the other basket had very **ra** figs, so **ra** they could not be eaten.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Proverbs 25:19 NASB*

Like a **ra** tooth and an unsteady foot, is confidence in a faithless man in time of trouble.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Good/Bad as Pleasant/Unpleasant, Beneficial/Harmful

1 Kings 5:4 NIV*

But now the Lord my God has given me rest on every side, and there is no enemy or **ra**.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Judges 16:25 NASB*

It so happened when they were **tov** of heart, that they said, "Call for Samson, that he may amuse us." So they called for Samson from the prison, and he entertained them. And they made him stand between the pillars.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Ecclesiastes 2:16-17 NIV*

¹⁶ For the wise, like the fool, will not be long remembered; the days have already come when both have been forgotten. Like the fool, the wise too must die! ¹⁷ So I hated life, because the work that is done under the sun was **ra** to me.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Good/Bad as Morally Good/Evil

Psalms 140:1-2 NASB*

Rescue me, O LORD, from **ra** humans;
preserve me from violent men
who devise **ra** in their hearts;
they continually stir up wars.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Esther 7:5-6 NASB*

⁵ Then King Ahasuerus asked Queen Esther, “Who is he, and where is he, who would presume to do thus?” ⁶ Esther said, “A foe and an enemy is this **ra** Haman!”.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Good/bad = morally good/evil

Good/Bad Applied to God’s People

Deuteronomy 1:35 NIV*

No one from this **ra** generation shall see the **tov** land I swore to give your ancestors ...

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Jeremiah 18:7-10 NASB*

⁷ At one moment I might speak concerning a nation or concerning a kingdom to uproot, to pull down, or to destroy it; ⁸ if that nation against which I have spoken turns from its **ra**, I will relent concerning the **ra** I planned to bring on it. ⁹ Or at another moment I might speak concerning a nation or concerning a kingdom to build up or to plant it; ¹⁰ if it does **ra** in my sight by not obeying my voice, then I will think better of the **ra** with which I had promised to [verb] **tov** it.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Definition of *Tov* and *Ra*

“Good” (Heb. *tov*): (1) what is morally/ethically good, (2) what is beneficial, pleasant or in good condition

“Bad/Evil” (Heb. *ra*): (1) what is morally/ethically bad, (2) what is harmful, unpleasant, or in poor condition

The Rare Phrase: “Knowing *Tov* and *Ra*”

The words *tov* and *ra* pick up more nuanced meaning when you look at the phrase “knowing *tov* and *ra*.” This rare phrase occurs elsewhere to describe children. Therefore, “knowing *tov* and *ra*” is a sign of maturity.

Deuteronomy 1:39 Instructor's Translation

Your **little ones** ... and your **sons**, who today **do not know good or evil**, shall enter there, and I will give it to them and they shall possess it.

1 Kings 3:7-9 NASB

⁷ Now, O LORD my God, you have made your servant king in place of my father David, yet **I am but a little child**; I do not know how to go out or come in ... ⁹ So give your servant a heart that listens, to judge your people, **to discern between good and evil**. For who is able to judge this great people of yours?

Isaiah 7:15-16 NASB*

¹⁵ [Immanuel] will eat curds and honey at the time he knows to refuse evil and choose good. ¹⁶ **For before the boy will know to refuse evil and choose good**, the land whose two kings you dread will be forsaken.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

As we can see from these examples, not knowing *tov* and *ra* is a quality of infants or children. The knowing of *tov* and *ra* is about moral discernment and maturity. The question is: Who will you allow to teach you the knowledge of *tov* and *ra*?

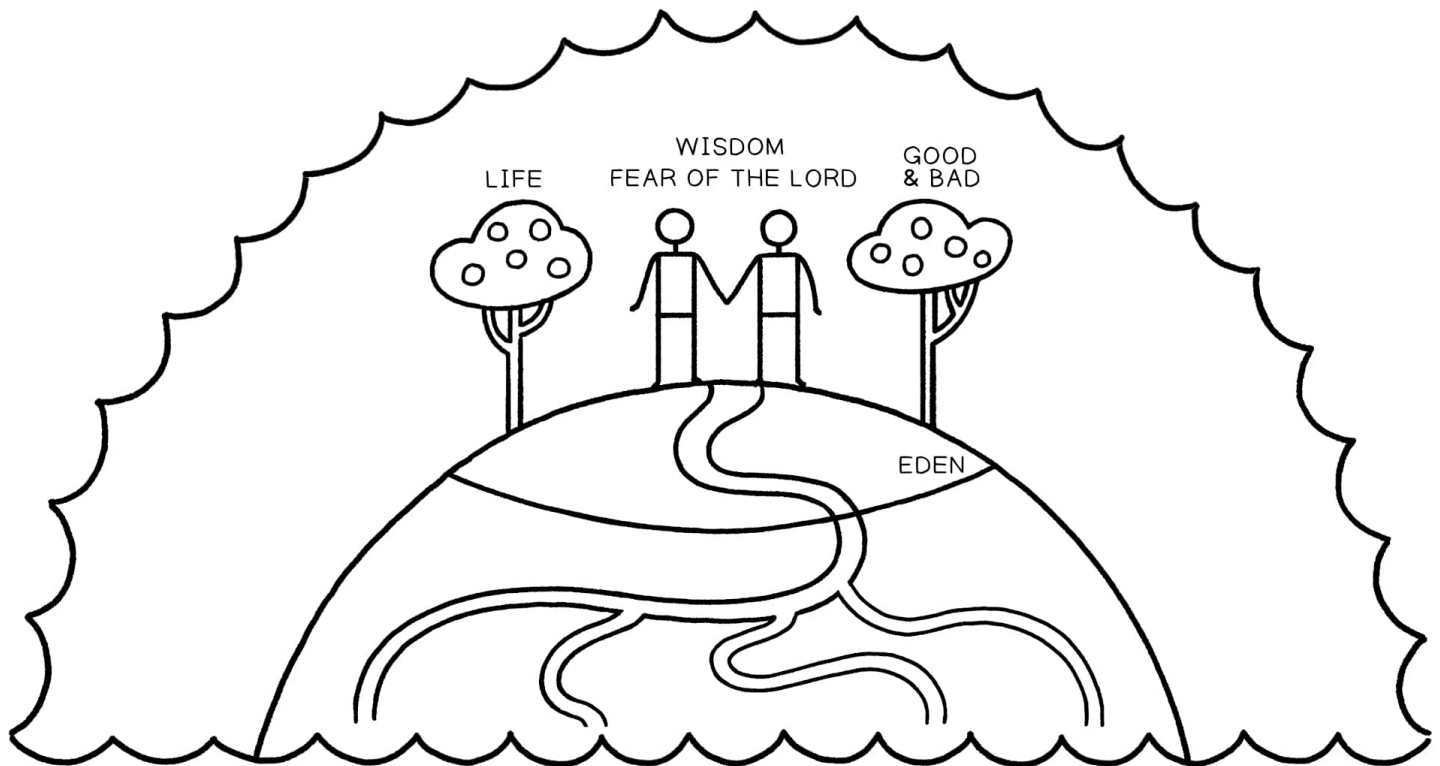
Genesis 2:17 NASB*

... but from the tree of the **knowledge of good and bad** you shall not eat, for in the day that you eat from it you will surely die.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

It is clear from Genesis 2:17 that there is a way of knowing *tov* and *ra* that leads to death. However, it also suggests that discerning *tov* and *ra* is actually a good thing that Adam and Eve will need to learn to carry out their purpose.

The Choice Before Adam and Eve



The Choice of Wisdom. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

The narrative in Genesis 1-2 shows that God knows what is “pleasant/beneficial” and that he will provide *tov* when something is not *tov* (the woman), that is, *ra*. So the tree represents a choice for the humans.

Will they live with God, allowing him to know/define *tov* and *ra*? Presumably they need this knowledge as they mature, but who will teach it to them? Will they learn from watching God’s knowledge at work?

Adam and Eve are portrayed as children. The tree of knowing *tov* and *ra* represents two modes for how to know and experience *tov* and *ra*. Will they take this knowledge for themselves so that they “become like *Elohim*,” knowing what is *tov* and *ra*? Or will they allow God to teach them wisdom?

Proverbs 3:13-18 NASB

¹³ How blessed is the man who finds **wisdom** and the man who gains understanding.

¹⁴ For her profit is better than the profit of silver and her gain better than fine gold.

¹⁵ She is more precious than jewels; and nothing you desire compares with her.

¹⁶ Long life is in her right hand; in her left hand are riches and honor.

¹⁷ Her ways are pleasant ways and all her paths are peace.

¹⁸ She is a **tree of life** to those who **take** hold of her, and happy are all who hold her fast.

It’s not a question of whether this knowledge is a good or bad thing. It’s about whose wisdom we trust to attain it.

The Choice Before Israel

The two trees at the center of the garden will later be set in analogy to the role of the Torah in Israel’s covenant with God.

Trees in Genesis	Torah in Deuteronomy
Genesis 2:9: “And God caused to sprout ... the tree of life in the center of the garden , and the tree of knowing good and evil .” Genesis 2:15: “And Yahweh commanded the human saying, ‘From the fruit of every tree you may surely eat. But from the fruit of knowing good and evil you may not eat from it, for in the day of your eating, you will surely die .”	Deuteronomy 10:4-5: “Yahweh wrote on the tablets ... the ten words which the LORD had spoken to you on the mountain from the midst of the fire ... Then I turned and came down from the mountain and put the tablets inside the ark which I had made; and there they are, as the LORD commanded me .” Deuteronomy 31:26: “Take this book of the law and place it beside the ark of the covenant of the

Trees and Torah. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

Trees in Genesis

Torah in Deuteronomy

LORD your God, that it may remain there as a witness against you.

Deuteronomy 30:15, 19: "Behold, today I have set before you **life** and **good**, **death** and **evil** ... **life and death**, blessing and cursing, therefore choose **life** that both you and your seed may **live**."

Trees and Torah. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

"Within the garden Yahweh had set both a tree of life and a tree of the knowledge of good and evil. Taken together, with their fruits connected to life and death respectively, the trees may be seen to function like the Torah, imploring Adam to choose life, just as Moses implored Israel in Deuteronomy 30. Resisting the second tree, the fruit of which offered wisdom independent from God, was Adam's wisdom, allowing him to perfect the fear of Yahweh through submission of his will to God's ... Just as for Solomon and his foreign wives (1 Kings 11), so too for Adam: the choice between the two trees is cast as a choice between allegiance to Yahweh and his wife, with whom he is 'one flesh.' This, through the cunning orchestration of the serpent, is the test for Adam."

Morales, Michael (2015). [*Who Shall Ascend the Mountain of the Lord: A Biblical Theology of the Book of Leviticus*](#). IVP Academic.

Humans as Trees of Testing in the Hebrew Bible

The tree in Genesis poses a test. It is desirable of sight and good to eat, and the humans take the fruit. As we keep reading the Bible, we see this pattern continue in future fail narratives.

- Sarah is good to look at, so Abraham goes down to Egypt so that Pharaoh will do good to him ([Genesis 12](#)).
- Joseph is beautiful of sight and good to look at, so Potiphar's wife takes his garment ([Genesis 39](#)).
- Daniel is said to be wise and good to look at, so King Nebuchadnezzar takes him to Babylon. The narrative is all about Daniel's refusal to eat forbidden food ([Dan. 1](#)).

These are just a few examples of a flexible image used to connect stories to a greater pattern.

Book Recommendations

- [The Art of Biblical Narrative by Robert Alter](#)
- [The Art of Biblical Poetry by Robert Alter](#)
- [The Hebrew Bible: A Translation with Commentary by Robert Alter](#)

Reflection Question

Was the knowledge of good and bad something that God wanted to keep from humanity? Why did God command the humans not to take from this tree?